The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

America condemned **Russia's** sham presidential election as "not free or fair" after early results showed **Vladimir Putin** won 87% of the vote, allowing him another six-year term. Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, described Mr Putin as a "Russian dictator" who was "simulating another election". Speaking after the vote, Mr Putin warned NATO that a direct military conflict with Russia would be "one step away" from a third world war—probably a riposte to France's president, Emmanuel Macron, who has refused to rule out sending troops to Ukraine.

China reported stronger industrial activity than expected, with production rising by 7% year-on-year in January and February, the fastest rate in two years. But the economic snapshot also showed that China's long-term challenges persist. The property sector remains in the doldrums: investment fell by 9% year on year, and the number of new residential projects dipped 30% from a year earlier.

Mr Putin said he had agreed to a prisoner swap involving **Alexei Navalny**, Russia's most prominent opposition leader, before his death in prison last month. It is the first time in years that Mr Putin has referred to Mr Navalny by name. He did not specify who offered Russia the exchange. Mr Navalny's allies have suggested that the Russian president ordered the killing in order to sabotage a swap deal.

North Korea fired short-range ballistic missiles towards its eastern waters, according to Japan. The launch came days after South Korea and America's armed forces finished eleven days of combined military drills. **Kim Jong Un**, North Korea's dictator,

has criticised joint exercises in the past as preparations for an invasion.

Israel's army attacked the **al-Shifa hospital** in Gaza city, in what it called "a precise operation". It said that "senior Hamas terrorists" were using the building as a base. There were reports of tanks being deployed around the facility. Al-Shifa is Gaza's largest hospital. An Israeli assault on it in November, while patients cowered, was described by critics as a war crime—although the designation is not straightforward.

Donald Trump's lawyers told the judge overseeing his civil-fraud case—who ordered the former president and his adult sons to pay $464m in damages—that he has been unable to find an insurance company to underwrite the bond. The court can seize Mr Trump's assets if he does not pay by March 25th; his lawyers asked for a reprieve while he appeals against the judgment.

Cocoa futures in New York reached an all-time high. The commodity's price has soared by 98% since the start of 2024. Extreme weather is partly to blame: a drought swept West Africa since last November, where most of the world's cocoa is grown. Supply has also been hit by price caps set by West African governments that have discouraged farmers from investing in their plantations.

Figure of the day: $2.5trn, the amount that the combined market capitalisation of Alphabet, Amazon and Microsoft has increased by since the start of the AI boom. Read the full story.

In the run-up to America's presidential election, we've launched The US in brief—a daily update to help you keep on top of the political stories that matter. Sign up here to receive it as a newsletter, each weekday, in your inbox

Photo: Reuters

Alleged social-media meddling at SCOTUS

America's Supreme Court will hear *Murthy v Missouri* on Monday. The case contends that the Biden administration pressured social-media companies to engage in censorship—and, in doing so, violated the principle of free speech enshrined in the First Amendment.

Louisiana, Missouri and five individuals complain that federal officials cajoled platforms to remove posts related to the covid-19 pandemic and the 2020 election. The plaintiffs argue that the government tried to "coerce private companies to censor ordinary Americans". They cite examples such as the White House telling Twitter to "get moving" in taking down an anti-vaccine tweet by Robert F. Kennedy in January 2021, or asking Facebook "are you guys fucking serious?" and badgering the company about censoring misinformation that July.

The Biden administration counters that presidents "have long used the bully pulpit to shape private conduct and influence the public on the issues of the day". It argues that only "threats or inducements", not "strong language", count as illicit coercion.

Photo: Getty Images

Why Ukraine is running out of shells

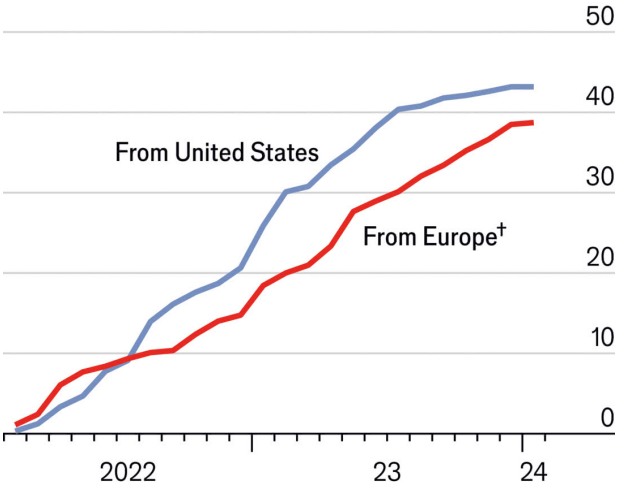
The worsening situation in Ukraine will be at the top of the agenda when foreign ministers from the European Union meet on Monday. Ukrainian forces have been suffering acute “shell hunger” since the end of last year. This, combined with exhaustion and sagging morale, was a major reason for their withdrawal from Avdiivka, a strategically important eastern town, a month ago.

Both America and Europe bear the blame for the shortages. MAGA Republicans have stalled a $60bn military-support bill for months; the EU has provided Ukraine with less than half the 1m shells it had promised to supply by March. (That deadline has now been stretched to the end of the year.) The European Commission has recently allocated €500m (around $550m) to boost Europe’s shell production, but will not hit its target of 2m a year until the end of 2025. A Czech initiative to source 800,000 shells may be more immediately promising. In the meantime Russia is pressing home its advantage.

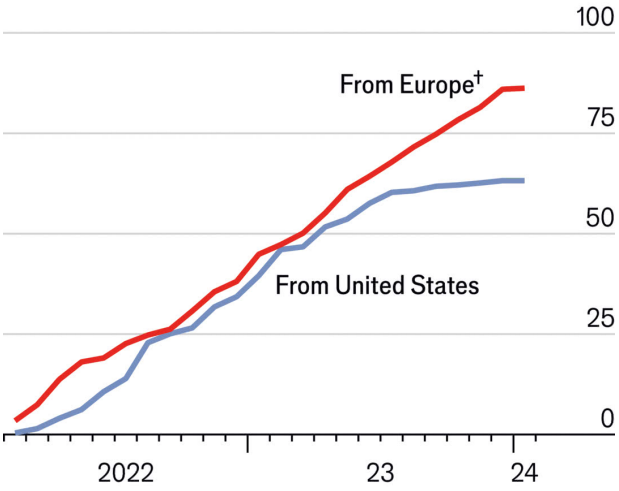
Don't give up now

Aid allocated to Ukraine*, €bn

Military aid



Total aid‡



*Specified for near-term delivery
†EU members and institutions as well as Iceland, Norway, Switzerland and Britain
‡Including military, financial and humanitarian
Source: Kiel Institute for the World Economy

Photo: Getty Images

China’s opaque economy

The strength of China’s economic recovery is becoming harder to judge. That represents a kind of progress compared with much of last year, when the economy was all too clearly weak. More recent indicators have been mixed. Exports and inflation were surprisingly strong in February. Credit growth and house prices, on the other hand, were disappointing.

On Monday China released further clues in the form of data on domestic economic activity in the first two months of this year (often combined in China’s statistics because the Spring Festival holiday can fall in either). Retail sales grew year-on-year by 5.5% (before adjusting for inflation), down from December’s figure. But industrial production grew by 7%, its fastest pace for almost two years. Extra working days may have helped. The leap year is yet another reason why China’s economic momentum is even harder to decipher than usual.

Photo: Alamy

Europe’s economy picks up

On Monday the European Union’s statistics agency will release figures for international trade in goods in January, as well as inflation data for February. Both are likely to provide much-needed good news. In December 2023 the euro area reported a €16.8bn ($18.3bn) surplus in trade in goods with the rest of the world, reflecting strengthening exports; a year earlier it had reported a deficit of €8.5bn. Inflation, meanwhile, is on a downward trend. The annual rate was 2.8% in January 2024, compared with 8.6% in January 2023.

Europe’s economic performance pales in comparison to America, where the economy has grown twice as fast as the euro zone’s since the end of 2019. That is partly because of European problems with red tape, high energy costs and a shortage of skilled labour. But Europe still has reasons to be cheerful: it remains an export champion, and its fiscal deficits are far smaller than the one across the pond.

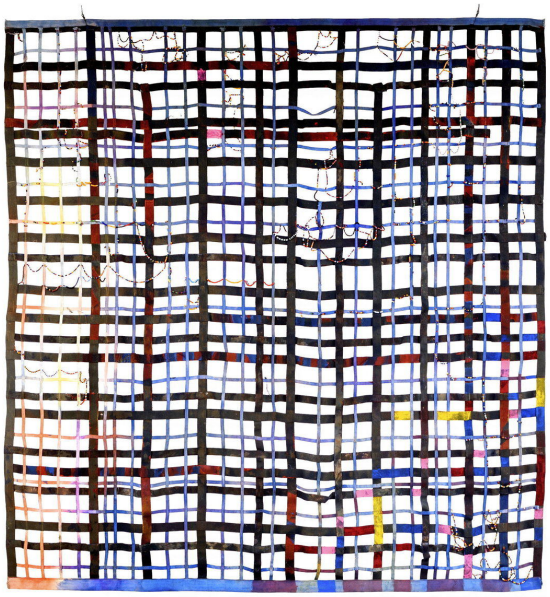


Photo: Gary Mamay

Modernism, out of whole cloth

Modernism is criss-crossed with grids—in fact, they define modernist movements like cubism and De Stijl (a Dutch style built on vertical and horizontal lines). Curves suggest old, natural forms. Grids signal something new.

“Woven Histories: Textiles and Modern Abstraction”, an exhibition which opened at the National Gallery of Art in Washington, DC at the weekend, locates the grid’s origins in the warp and weft of textiles. Even ancient weavers had an affinity with abstraction: they can only draw with straight lines. “Woven Histories” highlights textiles, often by women artists, as having played key roles in the development of Dada, constructivism and the Bauhaus in the 1920s and 1930s.

In the 1960s and 1970s the rigidity of the grid yielded to rising interest in folk art and basketry. Feminist and queer artists explored the embodied politics of fashion. As modernism waned, the weave loosened. But, this show suggests, textiles still tied 20th-century art together.

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each day this week. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and, as important, tell us the connecting theme. Email your responses (and include mention of your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners on Saturday.

Monday: Rastafarians use the name of which ancient Mesopotamian city to refer to the white western world?

> *We take our bearings, daily, from others. To be sane is, to a great extent, to be sociable.*
>
> *John Updike*